NCAI | Kunsthaus Bregenz

Press Release
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MICHAEL ARMITAGE, MARIA LASSNIG, CHELENGE VAN RAMPELBERG
Group Exhibition
19 February 2026 – 5 April 2026

The Nairobi Contemporary Art Institute (NCAI) in collaboration with Kunsthaus Bregenz (KUB) presents *Michael Armitage, Maria Lassnig, Chelenge Van Rampelberg*, an exhibition that brings together three distinct yet deeply connected artistic voices.

The exhibition opens on 19 February and remains on view until 5 April 2026.



Chelenge Van Rampelberg, *With Him, It's Fear* (1998)

Following its first presentation at Kunsthaus Bregenz (KUB) in 2025, this travelling exhibition arrives at the Nairobi Contemporary Art Institute (NCAI) for its second iteration, extending an intergenerational and transcontinental artistic dialogue between Michael Armitage, Maria Lassnig and Chelenge Van Rampelberg.

The exhibition unites three distinct, resonant voices whose practices share a sustained engagement with the human condition: corporeality, vulnerability, relationships, and place in the world. Featuring drawings and lithographs by Michael Armitage, drawings by Maria Lassnig, and prints and sculptures by Chelenge Van Rampelberg, the presentation marks the first time works by both Armitage and Lassnig have been shown in Nairobi.

Conceived through conversations between Michael Armitage and KUB Director, Thomas D. Trummer during preparations for his 2023 exhibition at KUB, the project reflects Armitage's deep regard for Maria Lassnig, whom he has described as one of the most important painters of all time, as well as his long-standing relationship with Chelenge Van Rampelberg, one of Kenya's most accomplished artists, who is also, to him, a mentor, teacher, and friend. The selection of works shaped by Armitage himself foregrounds influence, lineage and artistic affinity.

The three artists share a fascination with the human body and how it exists in the world. Each returns to questions of physical experience—how we feel, connect, suffer and belong—using the body as a way to explore what it means to be human. Though their work has developed in different places and times, they are united by this empathetic focus on our shared corporeal existence. At NCAI, this second iteration of the exhibition offers a renewed context for these converging perspectives, situating the dialogue within Nairobi and extending its relevance to local and global audiences.

The exhibition is presented in partnership with Kunsthaus Bregenz, the Maria Lassnig Foundation, the Federal Ministry of Austria and the Austrian Embassy Mission in Nairobi.

About the Artists

Michael Armitage (b. 1984, Kenya) contributes watercolours that navigate pain, political tension and moments of profound tenderness, particularly toward animals. His compositions, rendered in warm sepia tones, reveal a refined technical precision and emotional sensitivity. Through layered washes and carefully articulated shadows, Armitage constructs spaces that feel at once fragile and animated.

Maria Lassnig (1919–2014, Austria) is known for an inward-looking practice focused on bodily sensation and perception. Rather than depicting the body as a fixed external form, Lassnig renders it as a site of lived experience, a resonant space shaped by sensations, memory and biography.

Chelenge Van Rampelberg (b. 1961, Kenya) is represented through a focused selection of

woodcuts and wooden sculptures. Her works, male heads with pursed mouths, upright female figures and quietly expressive forms, convey a profound sensitivity to inner states and relational dynamics. Across her practice, Chelenge explores intimacy and vulnerability through softened contours and restrained gestures, evoking relationships between human beings, nature and the living world.

About NCAI

The Nairobi Contemporary Art Institute (NCAI) is a nonprofit visual arts space dedicated to the growth and preservation of contemporary art in East Africa. Through exhibitions, the development of an East African art archive, an extensive public program of talks, and a multidisciplinary educational program, NCAI serves as an inspiring cultural space and a resource for the thriving East African arts community.
Established in 2020, NCAI builds on a rich legacy of art projects and institutions in the region, and seeks to tell the stories of the artists and projects that have come to shape the region's contemporary art scene.

Visitor Information

- The Nairobi Contemporary Art Institute is located at Rosslyn Riviera, 3rd floor, Suite 307, Limuru Road, Nairobi.
- NCAI is open to the public on Monday to Saturday, from 10 am to 6 pm, and Sunday from 12 noon to 5 pm. We remain closed on all public holidays.
- Admission: **FREE**

For press inquiries, images, or interview requests, please contact Kelvis Wanjia at kelvis@ncai254.com or +254729238338.